

ANCIENT INDIAN HISTORY

MODULE 4

UNORTHODOX RELIGIOUS MOVEMENTS

JAINISM

Sixth century BC witnessed the rise of many **religious movements** in ancient India. People expressed their **discontentment** with the biased **Varna system, priesthood** and **complex ritualistic sacrifices**. It was against this background of **exploitation** of the **masses** and discrimination among people on the basis of **Varna system** that **Mahavira** and **Buddha** protested, resulting in rise and growth of **liberal** and **inclusive religious sects** in ancient India.

CAUSES FOR THE RISE AND GROWTH OF UNORTHODOX RELIGIOUS MOVEMENTS- JAINISM-BUDDHISM

THE VARNA SYSTEM & THE DOMINATION OF PRIESTLY CLASS

The varna-divided society seems to have generated tensions during the **sixth century B.C.** The Kshatriyas who functioned as rulers, reacted strongly against the **ritualistic domination** of the brahmanas and seem to have led a kind of protest movement against the importance attached to the birth in the **varna system**. The kshatriya reaction against the domination of the priestly class called **brahmanas**, who claimed various privileges, was one of the causes of the origin of new religions. **Buddha** and **Mahavira**, both came from **Kshatriya origin**.

AGRICULTURAL ECONOMY & THE IRON PLOUGHSHARE

The agricultural economy based on the **iron ploughshare** required the use of **bullocks**, and it could not flourish without **animal husbandry**. But the Vedic practice of **killing cattle** indiscriminately in sacrifices stood in the way of the progress of new agriculture. The newly emerging peasant communities who appear to have become dominant did not approve the killing of cattle in the sacrifice, as **cattle wealth** was very essential to **supplement agricultural operations**. The non-killing or Ahimsa preached by the heterodox sects appears to have made these social groups opt for the heterodox sects.

THE INCREASE IN TRADE AND COMMERCE

The increase in trade and commerce added to **the importance of the vaishyas**. The vaishyas being ranked **third in the brahmanical society**, looked for some religion which could improve their position. The patronage extended to **trade and commerce** in particular by Buddhism and Jainism made the merchants, rich and poor agriculturists and artisans to favour Buddhism and Jainism.

THE NEW FORMS OF PROPERTY

The new forms of property **created social inequalities**, and caused misery and suffering to the masses of the people. So the common people wished to **return to primitive life**. They wanted to get back to the ascetic ideal which dispensed with the new forms of property and the new style of life.

THE COMPLEX RITUALS AND SACRIFICES

The complex rituals and sacrifices advocated in the Later Vedic period were not acceptable to the common people. The **sacrificial ceremonies** were also found to be **too expensive**. The superstitious beliefs and **mantras** confused the people. The teachings of **Upanishads**, an alternative to the system of sacrifices, were highly philosophical in nature and therefore not easily understood by all. Therefore, what was needed in the larger interests of the people was a **simple, short and intelligible way to salvation** for all people. Such religious teaching should also be in a language known to them. This need was fulfilled by the teachings of **Buddha** and **Mahavira**. The code of conduct prescribed for lay people by these new religions appeared to be more practical than performing protracted rites through the **Brahmin priest**.

THE ORIGIN OF JAINISM AND VARDHAMANA MAHAVIRA

The changing scenario of the socio-economic order of the **6th century BC** led to the establishment of Jainism and Buddhism as **heterodox sects** later to be popularly known as **reform movements**. Jain tradition speaks of **twenty-four Tirthankaras (prophets)**. In the **Rigveda**, there are references to **Rishaba, the first Tirthankara** as claimed by Jains.

Very little is known about the life of **Parshva, the 23rd Tirthankara**. It is believed that he was the son of the King of Banaras who became an ascetic at the age of thirty, got enlightenment after **84 days of penance**, gave his message to the people up to the age of **100 years** and died in **Bihar nearly 250 years before Mahavira**. **Vardhaman Mahavira** was the **24th Tirthankara** of Jainism. According to Jain tradition, most **Tirthankaras** were born in the mid-Gangetic basin and attained **nirvana in Bihar**.

According to one tradition, **Vardhaman Mahavira** was born in **540 BC** in a village near **Vaishali**. Being the son of Siddhartha, the head of a Kshatriya clan **Jnatrika**. Mahavira's mother was named **Trishala**, sister of the **Lichchavi chief Chetaka** whose daughter was wedded to **Bimbisara** hence he also had connections with the **royal family of Magadha**. Initially, Mahavira led the life of a householder but in his quest for truth, he abandoned the world at the age of 30 and became an ascetic.

After wandering from place to place for 12 years, he attained **omniscience (Kaivalya)** through which he **conquered misery and happiness**. Because of this conquest, he is known as **Mahavira** or the great hero or Jina that is the conqueror and his followers are known as Jainas. He propagated his religion for thirty years and his mission took him to **Koshala, Magadha, Mithila, Champa** etc. He passed away at the age of 72 in 468 BC at Pavapuri near **modern Rajgir**.

TEACHINGS OF MAHAVIRA

The most important idea in Jainism is that the **entire world is animated**: even stones, rocks and water have life and they have soul. **Non-injury to living beings, especially to humans, animals, plants and insects**, is central to Jain philosophy. In fact, the principle of ahimsa, emphasised within Jainism, has left its mark on Indian thinking as a whole. According to Jain teachings, the **cycle of birth and rebirth is shaped through karma**.

Asceticism and **penance** are required to free **oneself from the cycle of karma**. This can be achieved only by renouncing the world; therefore, monastic existence is a

necessary condition of salvation. Religious texts written in **Pali** do not recognize Mahavira as an originator of a new religion but as a reformer of an existing religion. Mahavira accepted mostly the religious doctrines of **Parshva** but certainly made some alterations and additions to them. **Parshva** emphasized self –control and penance and advised his followers to observe **Satya** (truth), **Ahimsa** (non-violence), **Aprigraha** (no possession of property), **Asteya** (not to receive anything which is not freely given). To these Mahavira added **Brahmacharya** (celibacy).

FIVE DOCTRINES OF JAINISM

1. **Non- violence (ahimsa),**
2. **No lies (satya),**
3. **No stealing (asteya),**
4. **No property (aparigraha), and**
5. **Observing continence (brahmacharya).**

The five principles or vows when observed by the monks strictly are known as '**mahavratas**', but when lay members practice them they are called '**anuvratas**'.

THREE JEWELS OR TRIRATNA

The aim of Jain life is to achieve **liberation of the soul**. This is done by following the **Jain ethical code**, or to put it simply, living rightly by following the three jewels of Jain ethics. Three jewels or **triratna** are a metaphor for describing conduct and knowledge:

RIGHT FAITH

This doesn't mean believing what you're told, but means **seeing** (hearing, feeling, etc.) things properly, and avoiding preconceptions and superstitions that get in the way of seeing clearly. Belief in **True Prophets** (like Jain Tirthankars) **True Scriptures** (like Jain Shastras) and **True Preceptors** (like Jain saints).

RIGHT KNOWLEDGE

A person who has right knowledge will naturally free themselves from attachment and desire, and so achieve peace of mind. **Right Knowledge** is broadly divided into **five categories**:

1. **Sensory knowledge** (Mati Gyan): knowledge derived through the sense organs like eyes, ears etc. and the mind. It can be false or right depending on the truth and rightness of the perception
2. **Study Knowledge** (Srut Gyan): verbal or scriptural knowledge
3. **Remote Knowledge** (Avadhi Gyan): determinate knowledge of remote physical objects derived directly without instrumentality of senses or mind.
4. **Mind Reading knowledge** (Telepathy or Man Prayaya Gyan): All living beings with mind when engaged in thinking give different shapes to the mind according to objects thought of. The knowledge which can apprehend these shapes of other minds or thoughts of others is telepathy.
5. **Omniscience** (Kewalya Gyan): This is unlimited knowledge of the whole of reality which the individual soul acquires directly. Once omniscience appears, the soul is all set for liberation.

RIGHT CONDUCT

This means **living your life** according to **Jain ethical rules**, to avoid doing harm to living things and freeing yourself from attachment and other impure attitudes and thoughts. Jains believe that a person who has **right faith** and **right knowledge** will be motivated and able to achieve **right conduct**.

JAIN PHILOSOPHY

As regards philosophy, **Jaina philosophy** shows a close affinity to Hindu Sankhya philosophy. It also ignores the idea of creator God, accepts that the world is full of sorrows and **believes in the theory of Karma and transmigration of soul**. Jaina philosophy is that of dualism. It believes that human personality is formed of two elements: **Jiva (soul) and Ajiva (matter)**.

While Ajiva is destructible, Jiva is indestructible and the salvation of an individual is possible through progress of Jiva. In short, the **living and non-living** (soul and matter) by coming into contact with each other create energies which **cause birth, death and various experiences of life**. These energies already created could be destroyed by a course of discipline leading to **salvation or nirvana**. This means seven things:

1. There is something called the **living**.
2. There is something called the **non-living**.
3. The two come in contact with each other.
4. The contact leads **to production of energies**.
5. The **process of contact** could be stopped.
6. The existing energies could be exhausted.
7. **Salvation** could be achieved.

These seven propositions are called the **seven tattvas or truths or realities** by Jainas. On the basis of these propositions, Jaina philosophy states that if one desires to attain Nirvana, it is important for him to **destroy Karma**. One could gradually do it by avoiding evil Karma first and later other Karma. To equip himself for such a task a person should observe the five principles of the religion namely **Satya, Ahimsa, Aprigraha, asteya and Brahamacharya**. Jainism is essentially atheistic the concept of God being irrelevant. But it accepts a **group of prophets or Tirthankaras** who were deified men.

ANEKANTAVADA refers to the principles of **pluralism and multiplicity of viewpoints**, the notion that reality is perceived differently from diverse points of view, and that no single point of view is the complete truth, yet taken together they comprise the complete truth. It is one of the most important and fundamental doctrines of Jainism.

UNIVERSAL LAW Every mortal possesses the potentiality of becoming as great as they were. Jainism represents the **universe as functioning** according to **eternal law** continuously passing through a series of cosmic waves of progress and decline. According to it, the sole purpose of life is the purification of soul.

Unlike the Upanishads, Jainism preaches that the **purification of soul** cannot be attained through knowledge but only through rigorous ascetic punishment of the body thereby **freeing the soul** from the sorrows of life.

A monastic life was essential for full salvation. No lay jaina could take up the profession of **agriculture** since this involved not only the destruction of plant life but also of many living things in the soil. That is why strict limitation of private property enforced

by Jainism was interpreted to mean only landed property. There was no restriction on amassing wealth by means of trade and commerce. The practice of nonviolence in **Jainism had more of negativity** since it lays greater emphasis on vegetarianism and **precaution against killing of insects and animals** rather than on loving them.

PRINCIPAL SECTS OF THE JAINISM

By the end of the fourth century B.C., there was a serious famine in the Ganges valley. Many Jain monks led by **Bhadrabagu** and Chandragupta Maurya came to **Sravana Belgola** in Karnataka. Those who stayed back in north India were led by a monk named **Sthulabahu** who changed the code of conduct for the monks. This led to the division of Jainism into two sects **Svetambaras** (whiteclad) and **Digambaras** (Sky-clad or Naked). Digambar means those whose garment is only the four directions, or "sky-clad". 'Svet' means white and Svetambaras are those who wear white coverings.

DIFFERENCES BETWEEN DIGAMBARAS AND SVETAMBARAS

Digambar Jain monks do not wear clothes because they believe clothes are like other possessions, **increasing dependency** and desire for material things, and desire for anything ultimately **leads to sorrow**.

Svetambar Jain monks wear **white clothes** for **practical reasons** and believe there is nothing in **Jain scripture** that condemns wearing clothes. These differing views arise from different interpretations of the same holy books.

Digambaras believe that **women cannot attain moksha** in the same birth, while Svetambaras believe that women may attain **liberation** and that **Mallinath, a Tirthankar**, was **female**. The difference centres on the fact that Digambar ascetism requires **nudity**. As nudity is not **practical** for women, it follows that without it they **cannot attain moksha**.

Digambaras believe that **Mahavir was not married**, whereas Shvetambaras believe the princely **Mahavir was married** and had a **daughter**.

In the first Jain prayer, the **Namokara Mantra**. Sthanakavasis and Digambaras believe that only the **first five lines** are formally part of the **Namokara Mantra**, whereas Svetambaras believe all **nine form the mantra**. Other differences are minor and not based on major points of doctrine.

THE SVETAMBARA SUB-SECTS

Like the Digambara sect, the Svetambara sect has also been split into three main sub-sects:

- Murtipujaka,
- Sthanakvasi, and
- Terapanthi

Murtipujaka

The original stock of the Svetambaras is known as Murtipujaka Svetambaras since they are the thorough worshippers of idols. They offer flowers, fruits, saffron, etc. to their idols and invariably adorn them with rich clothes and jeweled ornaments.

Their ascetics cover their mouth with strips of cloth while speaking, otherwise they keep them in their hands. They stay in temples or in the specially reserved buildings known as upasrayas. They collect food in their bowls from the sravakas or householders' houses and eat at their place of stay.

The Sthanakvasi arose not directly from the Svetambaras but as reformers of an older reforming sect, viz., the Lonka sect of Jainism. This Lonka sect was founded in about 1474 A.D. by Lonkashaha, a rich and well-read merchant of Ahmedabad. The main principle of this sect was not to practice idol-worship

The Terapanthis are non-idolatrous and are very finely organized under the complete direction of one Acharya, that is, religious head. In its history of little more than 200 years, the Terapantha had a succession of only 9 Acharyas from the founder Acharya Bhikkanaji as the First Acharya to the present Acharya Tulasi as the 9th Acharya. The Terapanthis believe that idolatry does not provide deliverance and attach importance to the practice of meditation

JAIN COUNCILS & LITERATURE

In the **first council** at **Pataliputra**, the **Jaina canon** was divided into 12 sections which the **Svetambaras accepted but Digambaras** refused to accept this claiming that all old scriptures were lost. At the **second council held at Vallabhi** new additions were made in the form of '**Upangas**' or minor sections. Among the **12 angas the Acharayanga Sutta** and the **Bhagwati Sutta** are the most important. While the former deals with the code of conduct which a Jaina monk is required to follow, the later expound the Jaina doctrines in a comprehensive manner.

Teachings of Mahavira became very popular among the masses and different sections of society were attracted to it. One of the important causes for the success was the popular **dialect (Prakrit)** used in place of Sanskrit. The simple and homely morals prescribed to the masses attracted the people. The **royal patronage** by the rulers of **Magadha** later made **Mathura and Ujjain** great centres of Jainism. Jain councils collected the material of the sacred texts to write them down systematically, in **Ardhamagadhi**. But in the absence of popular religious preachers after the death of **Mahavira**, its division into two important sects, absence of protection by the later rulers, revival of Hinduism under the **Guptas, Cholas, Chalukyas** and **Rajput kings** also contributed to its slow decline.

JAIN CONTRIBUTION TO INDIAN CULTURE

Its contribution to Indian culture particularly literature, architecture and sculpture has been remarkable. Though the language of its religious texts had been **Prakrit**, it helped in giving a literary shape to some spoken languages of India. The temples and idols still existing in various cities as **Mathura, Gwalior, Junagarh, Chittor, Abu** have been accepted as some of the best specimens of Indian architecture and sculpture particularly the temples of Abu, the Jaina tower at **Chittorgarh**, the elephant caves of **Orissa** and the **70 feet high idol of Bahubali in Mysore**.

GROWTH OF ART AND ARCHITECTURE

Jainism helped a lot in the **growth of Art and Architecture**. The kings patronized Jainism. So many Jain images and the images of Jain Tirthankara were found in many parts of India. The image of **Bahuvalin in Shravanabelgola** in Karnataka (known as Gomateswara) is the **highest Jain image** ever carved in India. The Jain images found in **Mathura, Bundelkhand, Northern Madhya Pradesh, Orissa and Benares** are important Jain Art remains in India. The **cave art of Udayagiri in Bhubaneswar, Madhya Pradesh, Ellora and Maharashtra** are unique **examples of Jain art**.

The **Dilwara Jain** temple at **Mount Abu** of Rajasthan is a dream in marble. Nearly 90 percent of Jain temples are the gifts of single wealthy individuals and as such the Jain temples are distinguished for elaborate details and exquisite finish. The **Jain Tower** in the fort of Chittor is another specimen of architectural engineering. Innumerable manuscripts in palm leaves were written down and some of them were painted with gold dust. These have given rise to a new school of painting known as the “**Western Indian School**”. Thus, Jainism helped in the growth of art and architecture in India.

THE JAIN RITUAL-- SANTHARA

Santhara is a century old Jain ritual which implies **facing death** by a **person voluntarily** when he is nearing his end and when normal life according to religion is not possible due to **old age, incurable disease, severe famine** etc., after **subjugation of all passions** and abandonment of all worldly attachments, by **observance of austerities**, gradually **quitting food and water**, and by simultaneous meditation on the real nature the self, until the soul parts from the body. According to Jainism, it is a means for **self-realization**.

Recently, **The Supreme Court** has restored the **Jain religious** practice of a **ritualistic fast unto death** by staying an order of the **Rajasthan High Court**, which compared it to an **act of suicide**.

Sallekhana is not the destruction of life out of passions, nor it is motivated by **any desire**. On the other end, suicide is motivated by physical or psychological feelings of exhaustion, frustration, or both. Suicide is a desperate measure, triggered by **failure and setbacks** in life; it is an act of cowardice, a **surrender to the circumstance** because of **lack of will power**. According to the **Jains**, **Santhara** is the **exact opposite** of this.

In Jainism, the concept of **choosing the manner** and time of **one's death** is a **centuries-old ritual**. The devout Jains believe that Mahavira, the **24th Tirthankar**, allowed Santhara, or Sallekhana, as the **ultimate test of spirituality**, will power, whose ultimate goal is purifying body and mind and facing death voluntarily. Though both ultimately causes death, they carry huge difference as santhara practice is done in systematic way with full consciousness. For a religious culture that believes in rebirth, it certainly cannot be suicide. Further it is performed as an **ethical act** to attain **moksha**.

Misinterpretations and misunderstandings of such religious practices may often damage the **ethics of society** as whole taking in view the following points.

1. The practice can also be a mean to overcome **economic hardships** and other **grave problems** of life. It is very difficult to find out the real intention behind one's vow of **Sallekhana or santhara**.

2. Recent reports show that **women perform** it than men that forces one to think that religious belief cannot be the sole reason behind it.
3. Further, as suicide brings dishonour, individuals can take guise of such practice. It will also help them in earning **admiration and worship**.
4. It will also motivate others to adopt the same which can never be in the interest of any society.

For a **multi-religious country** like India, it cannot be a good idea to abolish absolutely such religious practice but a proper counselling of the individual and understanding their psychological thinking can help in differentiating the real objective of such rituals. The Practice of Santhara is ethical as long as they do not **violate any person's or family's freedom**. It should not be forced on anyone in the guise of family / social pride and must be based on true devotion. Further the practice of Santhara shall be subjected to the test of **rationality** and its outcome should be implemented after **proper consultation and involvement** of the people following such religious ritual.

REASONS FOR THE DECLINE OF JAINISM

LACK OF ROYAL PATRONAGE

The royal patronage of Jainism by **Bimbisara, Ajatasatru**, Udayin and Kharavela was not kept up by kings and princes of later times. Rather the **zeal and determination of Asoka, Kanishka** and Harsha to spread Buddhism came to end Jainism. As such, lack of sincere and determined royal patronage came to cease Jainism.

SEVERITY OF JAINISM

The **severity of Jainism** is also responsible for its gradual decline. Unlike the '**middle path**' of **Buddhism**, Jainism stood for **severe penance, meditation, fasting and restraint** etc. All these were too severe to endure. People soon became disillusioned with it. In course of time, Jainism, once adored, became alienated from the people.

UNINTELLIGIBLE PHILOSOPHY

Most of the Jaina philosophy was **unintelligible for the masses**. The concepts of Jeeva, Ajeeva, Pudgala, Syadbada etc. could not be understood properly by the people. Many could not accept the view that stone, water, tree or earth had **a soul of their own**. There was, thus, a gradual decline in popular faith for Jainism. This paved the way for its decline.

DIVISION IN JAINISM

Division among the Jainas after the death of Mahavira was the another important reason of the decline of Jainism. Some now advocated to literally follow the teachings of Mahavira, while others wanted to dilute the severity of Jainism. As such, the rift led to a division in Jain ranks. They were now divided into '**Digamvara**' and '**Swetamvara**' groups. The former, led by **Bhadrabahu**, gave up dress, adopted **severe penance** for self-purification and became indifferent to worldly life. The '**Swetamvara**' group, led by **Sitalabahu**, wore white dress. The division weakened Jainism and gradually led to its decline.

PREVIOUS YEARS' QUESTIONS (PRELIMS)

1. "Souls are not only the property of animal and plant life, but also of rocks, running water and many other natural objects not looked on as living by other religious sects."**2023**
The above statement reflects one of the core beliefs of which one of the following religious sects of ancient India?
1. Buddhism
2. Jainism
3. Shaivism
4. Vaishnavism
2. With reference to the religious practices in India, the "Sthanakvasi" sect belongs to **(2018)**
(a) Buddhism
(b) Jainism
(c) Vaishnavism
(d) Shaivism
3. Which of the following statements is/are applicable to Jain doctrine? **(2013)**
1. The surest way of annihilating Karma is to practice penance.
2. Every object, even the smallest particle has a soul.
3. Karma is the bane of the soul and must be ended.
Select the correct answer using the codes given below.
(a) 1 only (b) 2 and 3 (c) 1 and 3 (d) 1, 2 and 3
4. The Jain philosophy holds that the world is created and maintained by **(2011)**
(a) Universal law
(b) Universal Truth
(c) Universal Faith
(d) Universal Soul
5. Anekantavada is a core theory and philosophy of which one of the following? **(2009)**
(a) Buddhism
(b) Jainism
(c) Sikhism
(d) Vaishnavism
6. Mahamastakabhisheka, a great religious event, is associated with and done for who of the following? **(2009)**
(a) Bahubali
(b) Buddha
(c) Mahavir
(d) Nataraja
7. With reference to ancient Jainism, which one of the following statements is correct? **(2004)**
(a) Jainism was spread in South India under the leadership of Sthulabahu
(b) The Jainas who remained under the leadership of Bhadrabahu were called Shavetambaras after the Council held at Pataliputra
(c) Jainism enjoyed the patronage of the Kalinga king Kharavela in the first century BC

(d) In the initial stage of Jainism, the Jainas worshipped images unlike Buddhists

8. Consider the following statements:

(2003)

1. Vardhaman Mahavira's mother was the daughter of Lichchhavi chief Chetaka.
2. Gautama Buddha's mother was a princess from the Koshalan dynasty.
3. Parshvanatha, the twenty-third Tirthankara, belonged to Banaras.

Which of these statements is / are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) 2 and 3 (d) 1, 2 and 3

9. Which one of the following statements is not correct?

(2002)

- (a) The statue of Gomateshwara at Sravanabelagola represents the last Trithankara of Jains
- (b) India's largest Buddhist monastery is in Arunachal Pradesh
- (c) The Khajuraho temples were built under Chandela Kings
- (d) The Hoysalesvara temple is dedicated to Siva

10. Consider the following statements:

(2000)

1. The emphasis of Jainism on non-violence (ahimsa) prevented agriculturalists from embracing Jainism.
2. Cultivation involved killing of insects and pests.

Which of the statements is / are correct?

- (a) 1 only (b) 2 only (c) Both 1 and 2 (d) Neither 1 nor 2

MODEL QUESTION (MAINS)

1. What were the causes of the origin of the heterodox sects in the sixth century BC?

2. Assess the importance of Jain tenets and their relevance to humanity.

GALLANT IAS